trenches, which were now occupied by Chinese troops. No. 1 Platoon of Alpha Company under Subedar Nanak Singh put in a bayonet charge and after desperate hand-to-hand fighting, the depleted platoon fell back to rejoin the bogged-down companies.

As daylight lit up the slopes on the southern side below Se-la, all three 4 Sikh LI companies were caught out in the open. Positions on the northern heights that should still have been occupied by 2 Sikh LI were now under Chinese control. Majors G. V. E. Masilamani and S. Rajan, the two company commanders, put in a two-pronged assault to regain the old Indian positions, but they were stopped by the well-entrenched Chinese who were supported by accurate LMG fire from the flanks of the northern slopes. Despite the attack failing, the Chinese lost around thirty men and an officer. Masilamani now ordered the surviving men from the three companies to break south across the Se-la Ridge, go across a saddle and regroup on the other side.

Bravo Company was with the commanding officer on the forward slopes of the left shoulder of Se-la. With the Chinese attacking them from the north, east and west, it was fast running out of options (and ammunition). Firing off the last of their 3-inch mortar bombs and having withstood three attacks, at 9 a.m. the survivors were ordered to break across the ridge to the south as best as they could. 4 Sikh LI by then had broken up into small parties as the surviving men scrambled to get away. The Chinese stayed on their heels and repeatedly ambushed the groups as they made their way down the southern slopes, killing a large number who were by then quite defenceless. One of the company commanders, Major S. Rajan, was also killed in one of the ambushes. The bulk of those who survived managed to get away by escaping into Bhutan.

In a couple of hours, three fighting infantry battalions had been destroyed owing to complete confusion and indecision at the top; another battalion, 4 Garhwal Rifles, had been badly mauled, while the gunners and all other sundry troops found themselves in a headlong rush towards Senge. The main thrust of the Chinese that had been initially halted superbly at Nuranang the previous day was now a distant memory. The defences of Se-la had caved in with barely a push from the Chinese. In the annals of the Indian Army, this had to be its lowest point ever.

PANIC STATION DIRANG (18 NOVEMBER)